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in specific. Omicron is not only dominating globally but seems to be evolving to escape immunity from vaccines that previous variants had not had. Pfizer and Moderna have been working on Omicron-targeted vaccines. However, chances of such a vaccine being available globally in sufficient doses remains doubtful and by the time such a vaccine does reach the masses, Covid could well have mutated again.

So far, India has not allowed a mix and match of vaccines, one reason that has deterred many, as studies seem to suggest a "heterologous" (a booster shot that uses a different vaccine from the ones previously taken) regime to be more effective. A 2022 study by CMC Vellore found that a Covishield booster after a two-dose Covaxin immunisation gave the highest antibody response, compared with a Covaxin booster following two Covishield shots. Antibodies shoot up six times when Covishield is administered as a booster (third dose) to those vaccinated with two doses of Covaxin. The antibody response, though, isn't as high for a Covaxin booster for those who have taken two doses of Covishield. However, as Dr Rohan Aurangabadwala, pulmonologist, Apollo Hospitals, Navi Mumbai, says, "The main point is that one needs to be vaccinated. Waiting for a different vaccine as a booster should not stop one from protecting oneself in the present."

Many, however, are biding their time before a mix-and-match option is available. Pune-based engineer Anurag Bhatia says he is hoping one of the mRNA vaccines is available for the booster as he has read about their efficacy online. His wait may well have ended earlier this month when vaccine manufacturer Biological E's protein sub-unit Covid-19 vaccine Corbevax was approved by the DCGI (Drugs Controller General of India) to be the country's first heterologous booster in adults. According to studies, after a booster dose of Corbevax, neutralising antibodies against Omicron were found in 91 per cent of those who had received Covishield and in 75 per cent of those who had received Covaxin. But despite the approval, the vaccine is awaiting clearance from NTAGI, the final body that evaluates data on vaccines.

Vaccines, say doctors, remain essential to keep away death and severe Covid complications. "There is a sense that Covid is no longer harmful," says Dr Sushila Kataria, internal medicine specialist at Medanta, Gurugram. "Many aren't considering the symptoms of Long Covid—fatigue, brain fog, breathlessness—that can last months." The present surge may not be claiming lives, but it could well be leaving behind the burden of Long Covid. Experts hope that it also doesn't leave behind a new, deadlier, variant of concern. ■



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– Dr. Sushila Kataria
Internal medicine specialist, Medanta Hospitals